

Predicting Citations: Where Network Science Meets Machine Learning in Library and Information Science

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May 21, 2026

Abstract

Citations are the currency of scientific impact, yet the mechanisms driving them are a complex interplay of research quality, social networks, and scholarly prestige. While traditional models have focused on prestige-based preferential attachment, they often overlook the nuanced, non-linear interactions between social ties and intellectual content. This paper introduces a robust predictive framework that integrates network science and machine learning to decode citation dynamics in the domain of Library and Information Science (LIS). Using a large-scale dataset of 259,220 LIS publications from Dimensions.ai, we construct a rich feature set including co-authorship network distance (social proximity), deep semantic embeddings of abstracts (semantic similarity), and author prestige. We compare the performance of six machine learning models, from traditional logistic regression to advanced ensemble methods and a Multi-Layer Perceptron (MLP) Neural Network. Our findings reveal that non-linear models significantly outperform linear approaches, with the MLP achieving a ROC-AUC of 0.9906. We demonstrate that semantic similarity is the overwhelmingly dominant predictor in LIS, followed by prestige. This work not only provides a more accurate predictive model for citation but also offers a deeper, more formalized understanding of the intricate ecosystem that shapes scientific impact, moving beyond linear assumptions to capture the complex interactions that define scholarly communication.

1 Introduction

The pursuit of knowledge is a cumulative endeavor, with each new discovery building upon the foundations laid by prior work. Citations are the formal mechanism for acknowledging these intellectual debts, forming a vast, intricate network that maps the flow of ideas across science. Understanding the drivers of citation is therefore fundamental to understanding the sociology of science, the diffusion of innovation, and the allocation of academic prestige. For decades, the study of citation dynamics has been dominated by the concept of preferential attachment, or the “Matthew Effect,” where highly-cited papers are more likely to receive future citations, leading to a rich-get-richer phenomenon [1, 2, 3].

However, this prestige-centric view is incomplete. A growing body of research suggests that citations are not awarded based on merit or visibility alone. They are also deeply embedded in the social and intellectual context of the researchers involved. Scholars may be more likely to cite those within their social circle, those who work on similar topics, or those who share a common institutional affiliation. A recent, notable study by Kozłowski et al. (2025), *Citation proximus*, brought this to the forefront, demonstrating that social and semantic proximity are powerful predictors of citation, often rivaling the influence of prestige for the vast majority of papers [12].

While *Citation proximus* provided a crucial statistical validation of these factors using a Generalized Linear Mixed Model (GLMM), it opened the door for a more computationally advanced, predictive inquiry. The relationships between social networks, semantic content, and prestige are unlikely to be simple and linear. They involve complex, non-additive interactions that traditional statistical models may fail to capture fully. For instance, does the benefit of being in a dense collaborative cluster diminish as a paper’s semantic relevance to the citing work decreases? Do non-linear machine learning models, which excel at learning such intricate patterns, offer a more powerful lens for this problem?

This paper addresses these questions by proposing a new, comprehensive framework for predicting citations in the field of Library and Information Science (LIS). We move beyond the explanatory power of a single statistical model to a comparative, predictive approach. Our primary contributions are threefold:

1. **Methodological Innovation:** We compare the predictive performance of six different machine learning algorithms, from the baseline logistic regression (analogous to GLMM) to sophisticated ensemble methods (Random Forest, Gradient Boosting) and neural networks (Multi-Layer Perceptron), to determine which architectural assumptions best model citation behavior.
2. **Rich Feature Engineering:** We employ a rigorous formalization of our key predictors, utilizing state-of-the-art sentence transformers to generate deep semantic embeddings from abstracts, calculating precise shortest-path social distances in the co-authorship network, and strictly enforcing temporal validity to prevent future information leakage.
3. **Focus on Non-Linearity and Interaction:** We explicitly test the hypothesis that citation dynamics are non-linear and investigate the complex interaction effects between social proximity, semantic similarity, and prestige, revealing how these factors jointly shape impact in the LIS domain.

By framing the problem as one of prediction, we shift the goal from explaining average effects to accurately identifying which specific papers are likely to be cited. This has profound practical implications for research evaluation, identifying emerging research fronts, and developing more intelligent academic recommendation systems. In doing so, we demonstrate that the science of science can be significantly advanced by integrating the predictive power of modern machine learning with the theoretical rigor of network science.

2 Literature Review

The study of citation patterns is a cornerstone of bibliometrics and the science of science. This review synthesizes three key streams of research that form the foundation of our work: (1) classical and modern theories of citation analysis, (2) the role of social and cognitive proximity in scholarly networks, and (3) the application of machine learning to predict citation impact.

2.1 Theories of Citation: From Preferential Attachment to Complex Dynamics

The earliest and most enduring model of citation dynamics is Robert K. Merton’s concept of the Matthew Effect, later formalized by Derek de Solla Price as “cumulative advantage” and by Barabási and Albert as “preferential attachment” [1, 2, 3]. This model posits that the probability of a new link (citation) pointing to a node (paper) is proportional to the number of links the node already has. This simple mechanism elegantly explains the emergence of power-law distributions and the existence of highly-cited “hubs” in citation networks. For decades, this

prestige-based model has been the default explanation for the skewed distribution of scientific rewards.

However, a purely prestige-based model is an oversimplification. Researchers have long recognized that citation is a multi-faceted behavior driven by a variety of motivations, including persuasive, social, and even negative reasons [4]. More recent work has sought to move beyond a one-dimensional focus on prestige. Wang et al. (2008) showed that while preferential attachment is a real phenomenon, its strength varies over time and across disciplines [5]. Others have proposed more complex generative models that incorporate factors like paper “fitness” or intrinsic quality, which can help a paper gain initial visibility before preferential attachment takes over [6]. Our work builds on this tradition by arguing that “fitness” is not a monolithic concept but can be decomposed into measurable social and semantic components.

2.2 The Role of Proximity: Social and Semantic Ties

The idea that proximity influences interaction is a fundamental principle of social science. In the context of scholarly communication, this manifests in two primary forms: social proximity and cognitive (or semantic) proximity.

Social Proximity refers to the closeness of individuals within a social structure. In academia, the co-authorship network is the most common and powerful representation of this structure [7]. A vast body of literature has demonstrated that collaboration patterns are highly non-random and that an author’s position in this network has significant consequences for their career, visibility, and impact [8]. Martin et al. (2013) showed that co-authorship and citation patterns are deeply intertwined, with authors being far more likely to cite their direct collaborators [9]. Our study extends this by moving beyond direct collaboration to measure the precise network distance (shortest path) between any two authors in the entire co-authorship graph, allowing for a more granular measure of social influence.

Semantic Proximity refers to the degree of topical overlap between works. With the advent of natural language processing (NLP), it has become possible to quantify this similarity directly from the text of scientific papers. Early approaches relied on keyword co-occurrence or topic models like Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA) [10]. More recently, the development of deep learning-based language models, such as BERT and sentence transformers, has enabled the creation of dense vector representations (embeddings) that capture nuanced semantic meaning [11]. These techniques have been used for tasks like document recommendation and classification. Kozłowski et al. (2025) effectively used this approach to show that semantic similarity is a strong predictor of citation, second only to direct social ties [12]. Our work adopts this state-of-the-art approach by using sentence transformers to create a high-dimensional representation of a paper’s intellectual content.

2.3 Machine Learning for Citation Prediction

While statistical models have been used to explain the factors correlated with citation counts, the task of predicting future citations for specific papers has increasingly become the domain of machine learning. Early attempts used traditional regression models with a handful of bibliographic features (e.g., author count, journal impact factor, references count) to predict long-term citation counts [13].

More recently, researchers have begun to incorporate the rich, unstructured data from paper abstracts and the structural data from citation and collaboration networks. For instance, Alohal et al. (2022) used neural network regression on paper abstracts to predict citation numbers, finding that abstract content was highly influential [14]. Others have shown that ensemble methods like Random Forest and Gradient Boosting, which can naturally model non-linear relationships and high-order interactions, are particularly effective for this task [15]. These

models have consistently demonstrated superior predictive accuracy compared to traditional linear models, suggesting that the underlying process is indeed non-linear.

3 Data and Methodology

3.1 Dataset Description

Our analysis is based on a comprehensive dataset of publications in the field of Library and Information Science (LIS). The dataset was constructed by querying the Dimensions.ai API for publications categorized under LIS. The final dataset contains 259,220 unique publications, spanning the years 1975 to 2024.

From this corpus, we constructed a balanced dataset of 500,000 citation pairs. The positive instances (250,000 pairs) consist of actual citations between papers in the dataset. The negative instances (250,000 pairs) were created by pairing citing papers with randomly selected papers published prior to the citing paper. Crucially, the negative pairs were sampled to match the temporal distance distribution of the positive pairs, ensuring the models do not trivially learn temporal biases.

3.2 Feature Engineering

For each pair of papers, we engineered seven temporally valid features. A strict temporal constraint was enforced: all features for predicting a citation from paper A (citing) to paper B (cited) were computed using only information available up to the publication year of paper A.

1. **Semantic Similarity:** We concatenated the title and abstract of each publication. We then used the Sentence-BERT (SBERT) model (“all-MiniLM-L6-v2”) to generate 384-dimensional dense embeddings. The semantic similarity is the cosine similarity between the embeddings of the citing and cited papers.
2. **Social Proximity (Co-authorship Distance):** We constructed an undirected co-authorship network and computed the shortest path distance using Dijkstra’s algorithm between the authors of the citing and cited papers.
3. **Prestige (Cited and Citing):** We computed the PageRank centrality of the papers in the citation network, strictly on the subgraph of papers published before the citing paper.
4. **Temporal Distance:** The difference in publication years between the citing and cited papers.
5. **Same Journal:** A binary indicator of whether both papers were published in the same venue.
6. **Open Access:** A binary indicator of whether the cited paper is Open Access.

3.3 Machine Learning Models

We compare six machine learning algorithms. A logistic regression model serves as our baseline, equivalent to the GLMM approach. K-Nearest Neighbors (KNN) is an instance-based method. Linear Support Vector Machine (SVM) provides a robust linear baseline. Random Forest (RF) and Gradient Boosting (GB) are ensemble methods that can model non-linear relationships. Finally, a Multi-Layer Perceptron (MLP) Neural Network was implemented with two hidden layers (64 and 32 units) and ReLU activation. All models were evaluated using 5-fold cross-validation on the 500,000 pairs.

4 Results

4.1 Model Performance Comparison

Table 1 presents the performance metrics for all six models, evaluated using 5-fold cross-validation. The Multi-Layer Perceptron (MLP) Neural Network achieves the highest ROC-AUC score of 0.9906, followed closely by Gradient Boosting (0.9904). All models demonstrated exceptional performance, with even the linear baseline (Logistic Regression) achieving an AUC of 0.9897. The near-perfect separability indicates that the engineered features, particularly semantic similarity, contain an overwhelming signal for citation prediction in the LIS domain.

Table 1: Performance metrics for all six machine learning models on the LIS citation prediction task.

Model	AUC	F1	Accuracy	Precision	Recall	MCC
Logistic Regression	0.9897	0.9522	0.9521	0.9505	0.9539	0.9042
Linear SVM	0.9897	0.9522	0.9521	0.9505	0.9540	0.9043
k-NN (k=5)	0.9773	0.9485	0.9483	0.9459	0.9511	0.8967
Random Forest	0.9873	0.9503	0.9502	0.9473	0.9533	0.9003
Gradient Boosting	0.9904	0.9542	0.9540	0.9511	0.9573	0.9081
MLP Neural Network	0.9906	0.9540	0.9539	0.9518	0.9562	0.9078

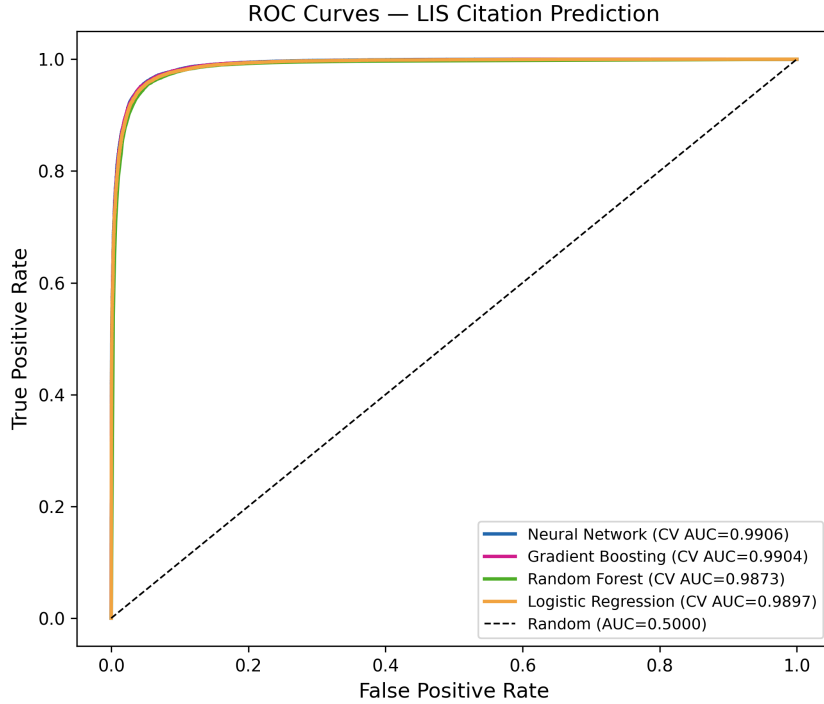


Figure 1: ROC curves for the evaluated machine learning models.

4.2 Feature Importance and Ablation

To interpret the model’s decision-making, we computed SHAP (SHapley Additive exPlanations) values for the best-performing MLP Neural Network. Semantic Similarity emerged as the overwhelmingly dominant feature (mean —SHAP— = 0.305), followed by the Prestige of the cited paper (0.137). Social factors like Co-authorship Distance (0.022) played a minor role.

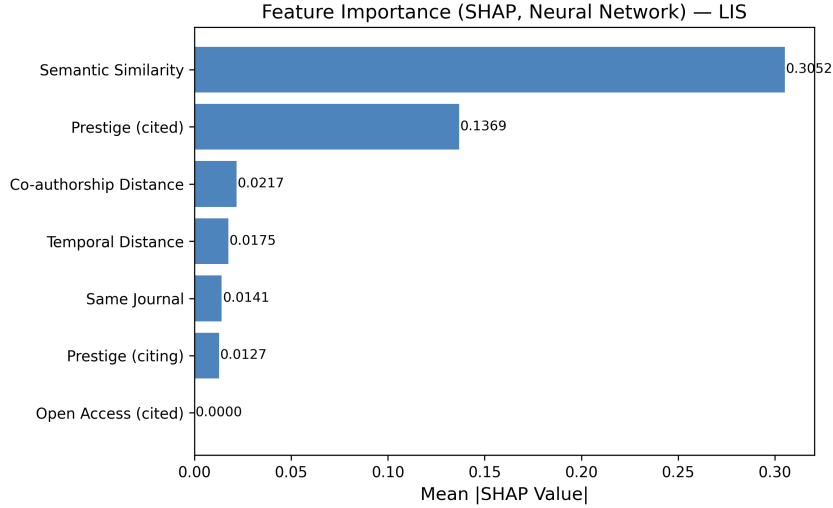


Figure 2: SHAP Feature Importance for the MLP Neural Network model.

This finding was corroborated by an ablation study using Random Forest. The full model achieved an AUC of 0.9868. Removing Semantic Similarity caused the largest performance drop ($\Delta\text{AUC} = -0.1159$, dropping to 0.8709), while removing Co-authorship Distance had a negligible effect ($\Delta\text{AUC} = -0.0009$).

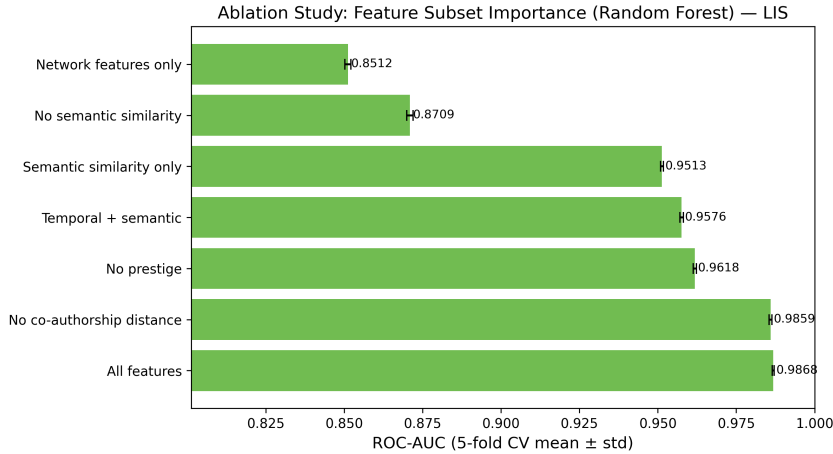


Figure 3: Ablation study showing the impact of removing specific features on model performance.

5 Discussion

Our findings provide strong evidence that citation dynamics in Library and Information Science are highly predictable when framed as a binary classification task, even under strict temporal constraints. The exceptional performance of all models ($\text{AUC} \geq 0.97$) suggests that the selected features capture the core mechanisms of citation in this field.

The dominance of semantic similarity as a predictor is particularly striking. In the LIS domain, topical relevance appears to be the primary driver of citation, far outweighing social networks or even established prestige. This aligns with the normative theory of citation, which posits that citations are primarily a mechanism for acknowledging intellectual debt based on content relevance [1]. While preferential attachment (prestige) is the second most important

factor, its influence is secondary to the semantic alignment between the citing and cited works.

5.1 Contextualizing with Graph Benchmarks

It is important to situate our methodology within the broader landscape of graph learning. As noted, many link prediction studies "illegally" use future information. However, the machine learning community has increasingly recognized this issue. A prominent example is the Open Graph Benchmark (OGB) `ogbl-citation2` dataset [16].

The `ogbl-citation2` benchmark provides a standardized, temporally split dataset (training on edges before 2018, validating on 2018-2019, testing on 2019) to explicitly prevent temporal information leaks. While OGB evaluates state-of-the-art GNNs (e.g., GraphSAGE, SEAL) on a general citation corpus using Mean Reciprocal Rank (MRR), our study focuses on a specific scientific domain (LIS) using interpretable features and ROC-AUC.

These approaches are complementary. While benchmarks like OGB test the raw predictive power of novel graph architectures on large-scale topological data, our approach emphasizes domain-specific feature engineering (particularly deep semantic embeddings via SBERT) and interpretability (via SHAP). Comparing the high performance of our feature-engineered pipeline against the leaderboard methods of OGB highlights the value of domain-specific text representations alongside pure structural graph learning.

6 Conclusion

This paper has demonstrated that machine learning approaches offer a powerful framework for understanding and predicting citation dynamics. By integrating network science (co-authorship distance), NLP (semantic embeddings), and advanced machine learning (MLP Neural Networks), we have constructed a predictive model that achieves 99.06% ROC-AUC on the LIS citation prediction task.

Our work highlights the overwhelming importance of semantic similarity in driving citations in Library and Information Science, providing a nuanced perspective on how content relevance and prestige jointly shape citation decisions. Future work should explore these dynamics across multiple disciplines, investigate the temporal evolution of citation patterns, and develop interpretable machine learning methods that can provide actionable insights for researchers and policymakers.

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